Mobile UX Prototyping, UXD-M
Exercise, Winter term 2026/27

Exercise Sheet 02
Prof. Dr. Simon Nestler

Severity: formula and rubric · The fidelity decision

What is this sheet about?

This sheet closes the analysis arc and opens your own project. In the first half you rank what actually hurts in the app you dissected on sheet 01, using a severity rubric you build yourself at the start of the session, from the template at the end of this sheet. In the second half you write your project's design question, put it under fire from your team, and decide which rung of the fidelity ladder answers it most cheaply. You leave the session with your fidelity block, the first half of what Part B presents.

Organisation: Work in teams of three, four only if the numbers do not divide; inside the team you are each other's critics. Assignment 1 is solo, assignment 2 runs in the whole team, assignment 3 in pairs (in a team of three, in a circle: A attacks B's question, B attacks C's, C attacks A's), assignment 4 solo plus a cross-examination by the person who attacked your question.

What you take with you: At the end of the session, **every person** holds a severity verdict (assignments 1 and 2) and a fidelity decision (assignment 4) of their own. The sheet has no upload of its own. Together with exercise sheet 03, its results are the content of **Part B**, your second graded presentation (15 minutes in your team with the lecturer, upload Wed 18 Nov, presented in Exercise U4); they count again in **Part C**, and they go into your **seminar paper**.

Part A in this session: Part A takes place within the time slot of this exercise, for each group in its own session (26 Oct for MUXP.1, 2 Nov for MUXP.2). Each team presents the results of exercise sheet 01 – claim checks, family dissections, team profile – for 15 minutes with the lecturer (20 points; upload by Fri 23 Oct, for both groups).

First assignment (40 minutes): Work alone for now; the team will attack your ranking in the next assignment.

- **Build your rubric (15 minutes)** with the template at the end of this sheet. Orient yourself on the Topic 3 lecture and its script: the formula, the three factors, the affected-group footnote and the candidate criteria are all there. This works whether or not you attended the lecture; if you did, you may take over criteria from the rubric the group built in the room.
- **Apply it (25 minutes)** to the app you dissected on exercise sheet 01.
- **Your top-3 findings,** each justified along the rubric's criteria: the formula factors from Topic 3 (task criticality × frequency × inescapability) plus the criteria you added (e.g. reversibility, trust damage, affected-group weighting).
- If a finding hits a particular group of users, count frequency and inescapability within that group; an average across all users hides them.
- Argue each finding along the rubric. A finding that merely annoys *you* needs a reason why it hurts *users*.

Second assignment (30 minutes): Exchange your rankings within the team. Merge the nine (or twelve) findings into one ranked list and defend every position you disagree on.

- Where do your rankings differ? Name the criterion that produced the difference: one that only one of your rubrics has, or one you applied differently.
- Which finding would move if you weighted the affected group differently?

– **The strain line:** one sentence per team member on where the rubric strained or failed to grip. This line is mandatory and must be non-trivial. It may name a breaking point you already noted in step 4 of your template; then say whether the others' apps confirm it.

Third assignment (45 minutes): From other people's apps to your own project: write down your seminar project's design question in one sentence. Start from the question you put on the Padlet for Topic 4, together with the recommendation card it got back in Topic 4. The Padlet is voluntary, and this sheet does not wait for it: if you brought no question, build one now from the finding that ranked first in assignment 2. Write a question a prototype could answer. (*"An app for sports"* is not a question. *"Do first-time users understand how to start a workout without a tutorial?"* is.)

Then put each other's question under fire; in a team of three the attack runs in a circle. The attacker checks:

– Is it a question, or a solution in disguise? (first check from Topic 4)
– Can a prototype answer it at all? What would you have to observe? (second check from Topic 4)
– Who exactly are the users in the question, and would two of them read it the same way?
– Which severity finding from assignment 2 (or from your own app history) makes this question worth asking?

Revise your question after the fire. You may leave this assignment with a different question than you entered it.

Fourth assignment (60 minutes): Make the fidelity decision for your (possibly revised) design question. Work alone; the person who attacked your question in assignment 3 cross-examines you at the end. The result is your fidelity block with four elements:

1. **The design question** (final version after the fire).
2. **Chosen rung** of the fidelity ladder from Topic 4 (sketch, wireframe, click dummy, coded prototype).
3. **Justification via the decision rule:** first the question, then the cheapest rung that answers it. Say which of the five jobs from Topic 4 the prototype has to do (visualizing, user testing, troubleshooting, faster iteration, stakeholder persuasion), and name explicitly what the cheaper rungs cannot show.
4. **The blind spot and its later cost:** what your rung cannot show or lies about (Topic 4: sketches about timing and gestures, click dummies about data and performance), and what that may cost you.

AI as sparring partner is allowed; the decision must be yours.

Then cross-examine each other with the final-presentation question: *"Why would a paper prototype not have answered your question?"* If the honest answer is *"it would"*, switch to paper.

Keep your severity verdict, your strain line and your fidelity block. Together with the results of exercise sheet 03, they are what Part B presents (in Exercise U4, upload Wed 18 Nov); the severity finding behind your question shows why the question is worth asking. All of it counts again in Part C and goes into your seminar paper.

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Template: your severity rubric

Fill this in on your own in the first assignment. Everything you need is in the Topic 3 script (“What severity is”, “The footnote the formula needs”, “Activity 2: build the rubric”), so it works without having been in the lecture. Copy the tables into your own notes or fill them in on paper; the rubric belongs to you and goes into Part B and your seminar paper.

Step 1 · The base formula (given). Severity = task criticality × frequency × inescapability. The factors multiply: if one is zero, severity is zero. Ugliness and the volume of complaints are not factors. Choose one scale for all factors, e.g. 0–3, and write down what each step means.

Factor	Guiding question (Topic 3)	Your scale: what 0, 1, 2, 3 mean
Task criticality	Does it hit the task the app exists for?	
Frequency	How often does someone run into it? Count within the affected group, not across all users.	
Inescapability	Is there a reasonable workaround? A detour that doubles the task does not count. Count within the affected group.	

Step 2 · At least one criterion of your own. The formula lacks something; add what it is. Candidates from Topic 3: *reversibility* (can users, or the organization, go back?), *trust damage*, *affected-group weighting*. The two dispute questions may help: “Does embarrassment count?” and “Does accessibility count double?”

Your criterion	What the formula misses without it	Scale	How it enters: multiply, add, or break ties
1.			
2. (optional)			

Step 3 · Apply it: your top 3 (assignment 1).

Rank	Finding	Criticality	Frequency	Inescapability	Own criterion	Severity	Why it hurts users
1							
2							
3							

Step 4 · Where your rubric did not grip. Every such case points at a criterion the rubric still lacks. These notes feed your strain line in assignment 2.

Case	Why the rubric did not grip	The criterion it lacks
1.		
2.		
3.		